Intro coming to later versions, for now let's get right into it.

What to talk about?

One of the most common questions I get is, "What do I even talk about?" And the answer is…anything you want, really.

Anything that you find genuinely interesting is a good enough topic for conversation. Because *what* you talk about doesn't matter nearly as much as *how* you talk about it.

How and why we connect with people

And this isn't how we normally think about conversations. We often think that in order to build a good connection with someone, we need to find some kind of major, obvious thing in common - working similar jobs, having the same hobbies, etc. This makes sense on the surface, since we tend to feel more connected to people who are more like us. But how many times have you met someone who seemed to have a lot in common with you, but you just couldn't make a conversation happen?

I'll even take it further: There exists someone out there who shares all of your hobbies and interests and can somehow make them into the most gut-wrenchingly boring conversation you've ever had. Rather than bonding over your mutual excitement about those interests, they'll just list off seemingly random details.

There's no coherent story, no emotional resonance, and no new knowledge or thought to be uncovered. And if you haven't met one of these people yet, consider yourself lucky. Because unfortunately, I have.

However, there are also people out there who you have seemingly *nothing* in common with, but would get along with phenomenally. Somehow, despite the two of you sharing no obvious interests, the conversation just seems to flow. This is because those surface-level similarities matter far less than we think. Great conversations - and further, your connections with other people - are built on uncovering fundamental similarities of who you are as people. They're built on sharing things like emotional experiences, the way you view and engage with the world, and the kinds of experiences you fundamentally value.

When you meet someone and things just seem to click, this is what is happening. There are fundamental similarities between the two of you that, once they're uncovered, make conversation flow easily.

Well, that's kind of a tall order…

Here's the thing, I'm not going to pretend you'll meet someone like that every day. I'm not even going to guarantee you'll meet one soon - *that* level of a perfect match is quite rare.

But you do have *some* of these things in common with a *lot* of people.

And this, I've learned, is the secret behind people who seem to get along with everybody. They understand that most people want to feel safe and comfortable, to have people around who accept them and enjoy their presence, to overcome challenges, and to be creative[1]. Each person may want these core desires to be satisfied in a different way, but the desires are the same nonetheless.

Great conversationalists understand this, and focus their effort on uncovering that preexisting connection. They understand how to take a topic you've never heard of and not only bridge that knowledge gap, but connect it back to experiences and emotions you already have. They know how to meet you where you are, and guide you smoothly to where they are. I've had the good fortune of meeting a few of these people, and they are responsible for some of the best conversations I've ever had.

Setting Expectations

Now, I recognize this is a starter guide.

I don't want to over promise what I'm able to deliver here, and I certainly don't want to present myself as some kind of

[1] not an exhaustive list, but a pretty good one.

master of charisma. But I have come a very, *very* long way from the kid who felt like he was flailing through every conversation, and just hoped he'd get along with *anybody* because he had no idea when the next chance for connection would come along.

This guide is the result of 5 intensely dedicated years to learning everything I could about social skills, another 10 years of working on them as part of an otherwise normal life, and now 2 years of teaching. I want it to be quick and efficient, only giving you what you need to get started and *damn* did I fail on the quick part.

If it feels like a lot, try not to get overwhelmed. One "bad" habit I've been unable to change is just how much I have to say. Most of the word count is examples and elaboration. If all you remember is the main point of each section, you'll do fine.

There are no magic lines

But first, let's get this out of the way: I know that some of you are hoping this guide would have quick lines or conversation starters. You might be hoping, like I did, that if you started a conversation well enough the rest would be easy. Such a thing does not exist.

And I think on some level, you know this. Because you wouldn't be here if it did. You'd have no use for this guide. You'd

have heard the line already, and you'd be out in the world using it right now.

Don't get me wrong, there are better and worse ways to start a conversation. You just still have to, you know, have the conversation. And if your followup is lacking, no introduction can carry you very far.

So while I understand that it feels daunting to learn a whole new skill, I assure you it will be worth it. And don't worry, all of this is far easier than you might expect.

How to talk about anything

If I asked you to tell me about one of your hobbies, I imagine you could do it without much struggle. And if I was clearly interested in what you were saying, I'm confident you'd be able to talk about it (engagingly, even) for quite a while.

But what if I asked you to *sell* me on that hobby? To show or explain to me why I *should* be interested in hearing more about it. I imagine this would be much more difficult.

Contextualization

And to be fair, this is a very normal thing to struggle with. Most people are naturally pretty good at talking about themselves and their interests to people who are already interested. They intuitively understand and focus on the more compelling parts of their lives, and even do a fine job telling a story here and there. What they're missing is the ability to contextualize, or give their listener the information and emotions they need to *become* interested in something.

This is why conversations seem to go nowhere so often. If you don't give context to the person you're talking to, you're gambling that either they already have it (prior interest in the

topic) or that they're willing to put the effort in to gain it by asking questions and directing you[2].

Fortunately, this isn't too difficult to fix.

Informational Context

There are two types of context in a conversation: Informational and Emotional.

Informational context is exactly what you think it is. It's the factual information someone needs to logically understand what is being said. And look, I know this feels like an insultingly obvious thing to tell you to do, but really intelligent people mess this up all the time.

I recently had a conversation with someone about their job in corporate accounting. It was a pretty good conversation overall (it helps that I majored in economics), but anyone who's taken even a cursory look at accounting or finance knows just how many acronyms those fields use. And while I remember some of the more common ones, this person used quite a few that I'm certain I'd never heard before. This made it difficult to follow much of the conversation unless I interjected regularly to ask for definitions.

Now, I'm certain they weren't being thoughtless - they were perfectly happy to explain whenever I asked. However, those

[2] To be clear, this isn't to say that people *won't* want to put effort into a conversation with you. But most people *will* be turned off if they feel forced to put in the bulk of the effort early on or for a long time.

abbreviations were just so common in their conversations at work that they'd just become woven into language in the same way a word like "phone" or "desk" is for the rest of us. This is the kind of information we often forget that we need to give people.

Of course, we don't know what anyone else does or does not know going into a conversation - and for that matter, neither do they. So the best thing we can do is just make it easy for them to ask.

You could argue that it's the other person's job to ask when they're missing important information. That's fair, and normally they will if given the opportunity. But if it doesn't register to you that whatever you just said is not common knowledge, you also won't think to pause there. You might be midway through another sentence by the time they would ask what you mean. This forces the other person to either interrupt and feel rude or wait for a polite time to ask and hope they don't get too lost in the meantime. Neither of these is great for having a good conversation.

"Before I start, how much do you know about ____?"

Fortunately, the solution here is pretty simple: just ask how familiar they are with the subject before getting into it[3].

[3] I do this even with subjects that most people have heard of.

This gives you a better starting point since they will directly tell you how much informational context they'll need. And even more importantly, it signals to the other person that their understanding matters to you. Interjecting with a question immediately feels less rude, and therefore they are more likely to do it. You can also take this a step further by explicitly telling them that they're welcome to interrupt you as needed. I try to make sure I always do this if someone is unfamiliar with the topic.

Now, because you're inviting this kind of feedback, you'll begin to learn what is and is not common knowledge about that topic. Over time, you'll develop a sort of script for how much context to give people at varying levels of prior knowledge. Eventually, to anyone on the outside it will seem *smooth and natural, like you somehow just get it*.

Emotional Context

In the last month[4], Hafthor Julius Bjornsson (best known as The Mountain from Game of Thrones) broke the deadlift world record. That's right, he's not just a TV giant. He actually competes in the sport of strongman, and he might be the strongest human to ever walk the Earth.

[4] You know, as of writing this in Sept 2025

The last competition he did had a max weight deadlift as the first event, and even offered a separate prize for anyone who broke the current record. Hafthor pulled a staggering 510kg/1124lbs and won $100,000 for it.

And I just can't bring myself to care.

To be clear, strongman is one of my favorite sports. I have trained and competed (at a *much* lower level, of course) for years now. And still, I don't care.

For one, the gap between the old record and the new one just wasn't enough to spark my interest. As insane as pulling 510kg is, it was a ~1% jump from the prior record of 505kg. Plus, the last two records, 505kg and 501kg, were his anyway and no one else has come close.

And that 501kg seems like an odd number, doesn't it? Yeah, he seemingly chose it to be petty. He was in an internet slapfight with the prior record holder, beat the record by a kilo, and the fallout and drama of the whole thing took over the competitive scene and really soured my interest in the sport as a whole.

Those first two paragraphs (the part above " I don't care") were informational context.

The actual thing that happened be simplified to, “Hafthor just broke the deadlift world record,” “someone deadlifted 510kg,” or if we really want to be nonsensical-but-accurate, “so Hafthor’s got $100k to spend.” But who is Hafthor, and why am I using his name? That sounds like a lot of weight, but why does it matter? This feat and its prize are kind of inherently interesting, and even then leaving out the details introduces a lot of friction to understanding the story.

Now, let’s talk about emotional context.

This is ultimately a success story centered around a novel feat of human performance. The obvious reaction to that sort of thing ranges from, “oh, neat,” to “wow, that’s impressive!” Kind of a positive, mildly surprised feeling. When you read the first half of that story (or if you saw a video online), that was most likely your reaction to the events. I, however, did not have the expected emotional response to this.

There are a number of factors that have caused me to have a different reaction, and if I want you to feel the way I do about this story, I need to make sure you have that information. The paragraphs below “I don’t care” are that emotional context[5] - they

[5] I wrote this story with the sole intention of separating information vs emotional context, but it ended up having a pretty interesting effect.

allow you to understand the story emotionally in the same way that informational context allows you to understand it logically.

Learning to Contextualize

If anyone's ever had the "wrong" reaction to something you said, or if they were less interested in a topic than you expected, they were most likely lacking necessary context.

Now, most of the way you'll learn to give better context will come from firsthand experience. This is scary for most people, since it carries the risk that you make a mistake and feel embarrassed. And as much as I'd love to tell you that social skills are just a skill and you shouldn't feel embarrassed for not being perfect, it would be a little disingenuous. It is true, but it took a long time for me to accept, so I can't expect you to start there.

So if you're not prone to embarrassment, the fastest way you can learn is by doing. But for the rest of us who are, let's look at how we can start learning better contextualization with minimal risk of embarrassment.

Since informational context is clearer, easier to learn, and inherently lower risk, you should focus on it first. Emotional

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Leading with solely informational context sets up the expected feeling. Suddenly revealing that my feeling is so different is a sort of dramatic punch, and the surprise is compelling. Then I give the emotional context after the reveal, which ideally brings the listener from the standard feeling to my feeling.

This is wildly outside the scope of this guide, but I figured some people would notice and I find it cool, so I couldn't help but point it out.

contextualization is more advanced, and mainly here for completeness of information and to help explain any confusing interactions you've had.

Ask

This really only works for informational context, and we already covered it in that section, so I'll make this quick. If you're talking about a topic and you don't know how familiar the other person is with it, ask. Ideally, work it into the first sentence:

P1: "What do you like to do?"

P2: "I've really gotten into this video game, ___, have you heard of it?"

By asking what they know - and by extension what you need to tell them - *before* you start talking, you:

- learn what information you need to give them,
- signal that you care more about them being able to enjoy the conversation than just hearing yourself talk, and
- make it easy for them to jump in when questions come up

Listen

Once you know what to look for, you would be astonished at how much you can learn just from watching and listening to other people. It can be people you personally interact with, or even things like shows and social media.

You should pay attention to:

- what kind of details they include/exclude
- whether those were things you didn't know
- whether hearing them helped you follow the conversation, even if it was as a reminder
- anything that seems to be missing

These will all give you an understanding of how that person is contextualizing information.

If you're looking for how they emotionally contextualize, pay close attention to how you feel while listening: whenever there is a dramatic shift in the way you feel about the subject, think about what they said that caused it and why.

If you want a source to study either of these from, standup comics and people who are really good at talking head social media are *masters* at contextualization. Just don't get discouraged if your current skill level is far behind theirs, this is their life's pursuit and you don't have to be *that* good.

Write (or at least think)

Lastly, I cannot overstate how important writing has been for me in learning social skills.

So I want you to take any topic you like and write out how you would talk about it if you were in a conversation right now - it doesn't have to be thorough, just a few sentences. Then read it back, imagining that you have *absolutely no information or feelings* outside of what you've written down.

For informational context, think about whether there's anything else you'd need to know in order to understand. For emotional context, imagine what you'd feel about it without the influence of your experiences. For most people, this one is a bit harder. Make any additions or changes you feel would give you the intended reaction.

While you're at it, look for any extraneous details that don't give significant informational or emotional context. Consider cutting them. Don't worry *too much* about this right now, we'll cover it further in a later section[6]. It's just good to think about.

At first, you absolutely should be writing things down. I used a private notepad in my phone, because it felt…well, more private. However, after an unfortunate mishap caused me to lose three years of stories, jokes, and notes, I moved on to apps like

[6] …and that section will be in a later version. Apologies for the cliffhanger.

Evernote and Google Drive. Eventually, you'll be able to do a lot of this in your head, but I'd recommend writing it down until you're comfortable with the process.

Remember that while all of these will help you make progress in a socially safer way, there really is no better way to learn than first hand experience. So as soon as you feel comfortable, bring it out into the real world.

How We Connect: Feelings, Experiences, and Values

My two favorite sports are skateboarding and a fairly niche strength sport called strongman.

On the surface, these aren't particularly relatable to most people. I mean, you've certainly heard of skateboarding, and maybe you even tried it as a kid. Maybe you've seen some clips of strongman on social media, or been to the right kind of gym and wondered why someone would bring rocks inside. But unless you actively participated in those sports, if I were to simply talk to you about doing them, it's unlikely that would be very interesting for you.

But if you asked me how I got into skateboarding, I would tell you that the first Tony Hawk game came out when I was 8 years old, and nearly every time I walked out my front door the neighborhood kids were out there skating. I tried it because it looked like a lot of fun, it was easy to get into, and it gave me a way to hang out with kids around my age. And *damn*, did it stick. 25 years later and I can barely go a few days off the board.

If you asked how I got into strongman, I would tell you that, like most men, I started lifting weights in an attempt to become more attractive to women. But despite my plan to lose weight and

get jacked, I found instead that I *loved* getting stronger. It didn't take long for me to shift my focus entirely from my weight on the scale to the weight I was adding to my lifts.

My sole complaint was that lifting barbells and dumbbells got a little boring, and traditional strength training didn't offer the variety that I really craved. So when a friend told me there was a sport that not only tested 20+ different lifts but wanted me to be both *big* and *strong*, it was game over. My dream of visible abs was instantly replaced with a dream of lifting bigger and bigger rocks.

Even though these stories are about *my* life and *my* hobbies, don't they feel just a bit familiar? That's because the moment I talk about my deeper experience in these sports, I touch on something universally human.

It doesn't matter if you've never stepped on a skateboard, you've been a part of some shared cultural experience. And you've almost certainly tried a sport or game because it gave you an easy reason to hang out with the people around you.

It doesn't matter if you've never even heard of strongman, because the story is really about learning that your priorities aren't what you once thought and how you can be suddenly struck by a passion you didn't expect.

Remember, we feel connected to each other when we realize the fundamental similarities between ourselves and another person. And since humanity is a largely shared experience, you'll have plenty to work with with most people you meet. The less you talk about *what* you do and the more you talk about *why* you do it, the faster you will uncover those similarities.

But that feels a bit…trite. Everyone has heard some version of, "talk about why you do things," at this point, and I aim to be better than that. So there are three main ways you can talk about things to create universality and conversational depth. And that's by focusing on feelings, experiences, and values.

Feelings

Imagine your close friend learns their all-time favorite band is about to play a show in your town. They find out when tickets are going on sale and plan their work break that day around it. They wait in that horrible Ticketmaster online queue, and are able to grab their tickets the moment they go on sale - normal price, too, no scalpers!

We'd expect that friend to be pretty excited, right? And even if you aren't a fan of that particular band, I bet you'd still feel excited for them. That's because the details of why they're excited don't actually matter: excitement is a universal feeling, so

you can still tap into that feeling and empathize with your friend's excitement.

What you feel, they feel (and vice versa)

Reflexive empathy, or our tendency to take on the feelings of those around us, is more or less hardwired into our psychology. This means that by default, our response to someone showing emotions is to feel them ourselves. This is necessary for bonding because it:

1. makes us more engaged in the conversation, and
2. creates a shared emotional experience between ourselves and others.

This also means that it is incredibly difficult to connect with someone if the conversation *doesn't* have some level of emotion.

When you talk about something in a neutral, emotionless way, you strip the conversation of any feeling and make it inherently boring. The only way people will naturally be interested about a neutrally-presented topic is if that exact topic is already interesting to them - *and even then* this won't last if their excitement isn't matched.

I once met a couple guys at a show who were wearing t-shirts for one of *my* all-time favorite bands. I was honestly pretty

excited to see them - the band is still quite small, and wasn't even playing that night. So I started talking to them.

They told me how long they'd been listening to the band. Then how many times they'd seen them, their favorite songs, other similar bands they listened to…with no feeling whatsoever. Just sharing information, the way it would appear in a spreadsheet.

It didn't matter that we loved the same band, even to the extent that *one of them had a tattoo of the band's logo on his leg*. Within two minutes, all feelings of excitement faded away. My inherent interest in the band was clashing with the lack of emotion in the conversation, and it became exhausting to try to stay emotionally engaged.

After a few more sentences, the temptation of standing quietly against a nearby wall won out, and I excused myself from the conversation.

Make sure to include your feelings about whatever you talk about. If you have something coming up that you're excited for, show your excitement. If you're talking about a problem at work that frustrates you, say you're frustrated. Yes, while I wouldn't

recommend this as a goal, in my experience it is often better to be negative than neutral[7].

I know this will be difficult for some of you, because it was *very* difficult for me. Showing your internal state like this leaves you more open to being judged, and makes it more painful when someone isn't interested. But if *you* don't do it, you're left hoping that *everyone else* will. This is a gamble with poor odds, and it virtually guarantees that the bulk of your conversations will be boring and go nowhere.

At a bare minimum, if you're not comfortable *showing* much emotion, at least *tell* people what you're feeling. All that matters is that you add emotional relevance to what you're saying.

Experiences

Let's think back to that hypothetical friend of yours and their hypothetical concert tickets. More specifically, how they got them. Why did I present this as a story rather than just explaining reflexive empathy? I could have easily said, "you know how when your friends are excited, you feel it too?" to convey the same message, right?

Not exactly. Stories and storytelling are another central part of how people communicate. By fleshing out a short story, even

[7] This needs a LOT of nuance that a later version will go into. For now, if you're new to emotional expression, just keep it light and happy.

one that simple and entirely hypothetical, I made it easier for you to understand and remember that section. And while plenty of people who are more intelligent and better educated than I am have published work on why this happens, I'm going on vibes and first hand experience for this one.

I believe stories have this effect on us because they:

1. Establish causality
2. Create emotional connection points

Establishing causality

Look, I'm aware this is an instructional e-book, or course, or whatever I've decided to release it as. I'm aware that if I'd just said, "imagine your friend is excited," you wouldn't have pushed back. You likely wouldn't have wondered what caused their excitement or tried to figure out which friend I'm hypothetically referring to. However, giving a reason for your friend's happiness makes it feel more real.

People crave causality. We want to understand why things happen, to know that thing A was caused by thing B.

Now, everyday conversation and minor examples like the one here are rarely important enough that anyone will be bothered by a lack of explanation. However, if you happen to have a quick anecdote or experience that offers some causality to the current conversation, it is usually good to share it.

One thing I've seen many people take too is how much explanation they give. So as a rule of thumb, most situations only need one layer of causality (a -> b, not a -> b -> c), given in 1-3 sentences. While some situations may call for more, no one will be unhappy if you're in that range.

Connection Points

The other reason I believe we find stories and conversations about experiences so engaging is that they create more points of connection for us.

Using our concert ticket story example again, stripping away the details leaves us with a story that is broadly relatable:

- a person learns about something they want
- they plan and make the effort needed to get it
- but there is still the possibility of getting unlucky and losing out
- in the end, they are successful

Every person who has ever lived has an experience that follows that rough outline. The details are usually different from a concert and Ticketmaster's bullshit business model (I'm totally not mad about this), but the core is the same. So when we hear this story, we subconsciously recognize the core, and map our own experience onto it. The protagonist's want, effort, anxiety, and

triumph become our own, so we are deeply engaged in the conversation *and* feel closer to the person we're talking to.

…assuming, of course, that it's told well - but more on that later[8].

A good story is little more than a universal feeling explained by an experience. So if you want people to connect better to you, you need to share your experiences. Tell people how you found your hobbies, what drew you to your line of work, or whatever experiences you have that connect you to the topic at hand. And don't forget to ask for theirs.

If you're worried, you can start small. It's hard to overshare or bore people with a 3- or 4-sentence story. If it helps, write some out ahead of time. This allows you to tighten them up without the pressure of another person hearing it.

But whenever possible, share your experiences and ask about theirs.

Values

I hate to do the whole "self-help book defines a word" thing, but the word "values" has gained a fairly specific meaning to a lot

[8] The storytelling section didn't make this version, but it's coming.

of people. We tend to think of values in terms of ethics or politics, which are often deeply-held and polarizing.

But here, we're talking about something far more foundational: When I say "values," I literally mean *what you value*.

I'm talking about the things you want in your life. The qualities a thing has that makes you enjoy it or want it. How you want to spend your time, not just in terms of your entire life but also on a minute-to-minute basis. This certainly encapsulates your ethical and political values, but also simply why you enjoy the things you do.

I mentioned earlier that my love for strongman stems from my desire to be strong and have a variety of experiences. Those are things I value.

This is already better than just saying, "I like sport," but we can go deeper if we want. Because my desire to be strong is rooted in how highly I value personal agency. I dislike feeling helpless and out of control, so anything that improves my ability to impact the world and my experience in it is really attractive to me. This is also why I chose to do this job. Not only did learning social skills have a dramatic impact on my ability to find people I enjoyed spending time with, working for myself gives me near-infinite agency over my time.

And notice that I mentioned valuing variety, not novelty. Because I actually don't think I would have liked strongman when it first became a sport.

Today, strongman tests about 15 movements regularly, with another 10-20 occasionally being thrown in. Usually a competition will have 5 events: 4-5 from the standard 15, and 0-1 from the grab bag. This is the sweet spot for me.

When the sport originated in the 1970's-1980's, it was all random. World's Strongest Man didn't even announce events, so no one knew what they would be doing. The athletes just had to be generally strong and hope they could figure it out. It was the meathead equivalent of musicians improvising. That's too much for me, I need *some* kind of consistency. But I've known musicians who love nothing more than improvising and people who run strongman comps by pulling events from a hat.

You've probably noticed again that the more basic we go with these values, the more they are either universally shared or universally understandable. This is, again, not an accident.

Most people value being able to provide a life for themselves and the people they love. They value having personal agency and the ability to shape their own lives. They value their time, the things that bring them joy, being able to give help or joy to the

people they care about, and their impact on the world around them. The way they believe these things could be achieved may differ, but the core of what they want is the same.

Now, there are some values that oppose each other, either directly or indirectly. Some people value novelty very highly, others value consistency. These are directly opposed. Agency isn't necessarily the opposite of safety, but much of what you'd have to do to pursue one comes at the cost of the other, so they are indirectly opposed.

Understand that everything you choose to do touches on some core value that you hold. Maybe you wouldn't do your job if you didn't need money, but you find this particular line of work challenging and interesting. Or maybe you've chosen a fairly grueling field like finance or medicine because it pays well and financial security is *really* important to you, which is often true of people who grew up without financial security[9].

By sharing your values in this way, you give whoever you're talking to real information about who you are. By asking questions that lead them to share their values, you gain real information about who they are.

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[9] I, for example, value my time and minute-to-minute agency extraordinarily highly. I've had jobs with long hours and good pay that left me desperate to trade it all away for some of my time back.

I also value the impact that I have on the world around me. And despite graduating and interning in a lucrative field, I was deeply unhappy with the impact it had.

This is actually why I opted to leave that field and take the chance on teaching social skills for a living (Shout out to my girlfriend, Sarah, for taking that in stride. And to you for supporting it.)

This can create some great moments and fast friendships, where you get to jump on some core similarity and excitedly discuss how both your lives reflect that value.

But even if you do find yourselves with certain opposing values like consistency vs novelty, it often opens up a much deeper and more interesting conversation than you would have otherwise. So think about why you do the things you do, what you value in your life, and lead your conversations there.

Make anything relatable: The 4 C's

So take this one step further, and talk about why people actually enjoy the things we do. As far as I can tell, there are four things we want from anything we do:

We want to:

1. overcome challenges
    - competitive sports, skill-heavy games like Hollow Knight and Dark Souls
2. be creative
    - art/music, writing
3. connect with other people
    - pretty much anything with a group setting
4. feel comfort
    - watching old shows, crafts, reading

If you think about anything that you enjoy doing, I bet you'll find that it gives you one or more of these things. Since these are fairly universal motivators, this is how you make the things you enjoy relatable and interesting.

Most, if not all, hobbies can fill more than one of these motivators - and the ones people become *really* passionate about often touch on all of them.

This has a few interesting implications.

Not always what you expect

For one, this means it's not always immediately obvious which of these categories a hobby fits into.

I've played music, a quintessentially creative hobby, for as long as I can remember. But I've actually spent very little of that time writing. What I've really enjoyed is the challenge of getting better at singing and playing guitar, so most of my time has been spent learning more and more difficult songs. In this case, it's not just that the "creative" hobby happened to fill a different role for me, it has been decidedly *not* creative.

And I'll add a quick reminder that the role any given interest of yours fills is not static. Case in point, I recently started to really work on learning how to write music. It's far from a smooth or comfortable process, but I'm enjoying it so much that it's completely replaced

Same interest, different wants

This also means that not everyone who does your hobby does it for the same reasons you do.

If you want to jump in a game of League of Legends to laugh and have a little fun with friends (connection), inviting the hyper competitive tryhard in your life (challenge - also me in my 20's) is going to be a bad time for everyone involved. Their constant

pings and urgent callouts[10] will interrupt you from using the game to facilitate connecting with your friends, and your casual treatment of the game will hold them back from fully engaging in the competition of the game. Similarly, I've learned to turn down invitations to jam with other musicians. They tend to be *fully* creative/improvisational, and I've usually found myself somewhere between bored and lost.

If you've ever struggled to make conversation with someone who shared your interests, this is most likely the reason. When people talk about one of their hobbies, they'll usually talk about their experience doing it and what about the hobby is exciting for them. This is essentially an attempt to connect over what seems to be a shared experience. But if your reason for enjoying the hobby is completely different from theirs, you don't actually have that shared experience.

The trick here is to recognize when that happens, and shift the conversation's focus. Instead of trying to connect over the shared experience of doing the hobby, look to learn more about it by the different ways you engage with it. This means letting go of many of the conversational shortcuts we get to take when we *do* have a shared experience, giving a lot more context, and focusing on what is universal about your interest. In many ways, you'll

[10] For those of you who are too employed to understand this example, it just means that people with exclusively different motivations will struggle to enjoy doing the hobby together.

want to treat it more like an interest you *don't* share than one you do.

Now, while this approach *can* turn an apparent nonstarter into a great conversation, it's far from a guarantee that it will. Having the same interest with entirely different motivations is one of the most difficult scenarios in my experience. Even with the progress I've made in my own social skills, these types of conversations regularly fail to start. So be gracious with yourself if it happens to you.

That said, the inverse scenario - realizing that you and the person you're talking to have the same fundamental motivation for entirely different hobbies - might be my favorite conversation to have.

Different interests, same wants

What I find most interesting about all of this is how you can use it to connect over entirely different hobbies if they have the same core motivation.

I was talking to a woman at my old gym about a rugby tournament she had coming up. At one point, she mentioned a problem her team was having that reminded me of my gaming days:

Me: “How are you feeling about the tournament?”

Her: “I feel pretty good, except that we have a few new players that we haven’t really had a chance to get comfortable with yet.

Me: “Oh, I know that feeling. I used to be into competitive gaming, and once had to fill two slots on our team with people we’d literally never met before.”

Her: “Oof, how’d that go?”

Me: “Not terrible, actually! I mean, we didn’t get very far, but we had some surprisingly good games. Do you guys have any plans to break in your new additions?”

Because her foundational interest in rugby matched mine in gaming (challenge), I was able to connect them and bring my experience to the conversation. It didn’t matter that I’d never watched, much less played, rugby. The experience of competition, tournaments, and new teammates is the same.

And this is a really cool way to connect with someone. Not only does it demonstrate that core similarity that fosters a good conversation, you get a sort of bonus for the surprise.

Now, people are often afraid to make these kinds of connections in conversation, and I understand why. It’s pretty off-putting when someone does it badly, in a way that we really

notice. For example, it wouldn't have worked if I'd immediately started talking about my gaming experience in response to her just talking about rugby. It would have come off either attention-seeking or like I just wanted to talk about myself.

Fortunately (for you, that is), I've had enough experience on both sides of this being messed up that I can teach you the common traps, how to avoid them, and how to do it well.

Look for close conceptual connections

The conceptual connection, or how similar your topic feels to theirs, should be pretty close. Even though sports and gaming are inherently very similar, the fact that one is heavily physical and the other is heavily sedentary makes them feel very different.

Ideally, you want to make sure the connection feels clear as you say it. My personal goal is that I can explain the conceptual connection in half a sentence or less, but I'll often accept a sentence or two if the potential payoff feels good enough.

If we look at this example, we have:

rugby ←→ gaming

(too far)

rugby ←→ competition ←→ gaming

(much better, I'll often take these)

rugby ←→ competition ←→ team dynamic ←→ gaming (excellent)

The connection between her competitive rugby and my competitive gaming actually came to mind as soon as she mentioned it, but I opted to wait for a closer one before bringing it up. Don't be afraid to exercise a little patience - often the questions that naturally come to mind will nudge the conversation in the right direction anyway.

Share, then send it back to them

Notice how quickly I shifted the focus back to her once I made the connection. I made the connecting statement, she asked a question about it, and I ended my answer by asking a question about her original topic. Your goal here is not to shift the focus to your hobby or experience, your goal is to introduce that topic as an option for the conversation.

Remember, this conversation is currently about the other person. You don't want to take over, you want to give yourselves more options for a back-and-forth.

This is the most important thing you can do to ensure it doesn't feel like you're trying to take over. Because the people

who *are* don't send the conversation back, they use the connection as a jumping off point to talk about them.

And if it's a connection you're really excited to talk more about, don't worry. Now that you've introduced it, you can refer back to it throughout the conversation. Plus, once the person you're talking to feels ready to transition off of their original topic, they will very often ask about yours.

Whoops, I took over the conversation

Sometimes, you can't help it. Your brain makes a connection that just feels too good, and you catch yourself forgetting to send it back to them. By the time you regain control of your mouth, it's been a solid few minutes since either of you last mentioned their original topic.

That's okay, it happens to all of us[11].

When you catch yourself, simply acknowledge it and offer to bring the conversation back to their topic. It's absolutely possible to do this in a "smooth" or indirect way, but doing it directly is far better than not doing it at all.

[11] I assume, at least. It certainly happens to me a lot.

Direct: “Oh, I just realized I got carried away there. Sorry about that! You were talking about _____, right?”

Indirect: “...which reminds me, what were you saying about ____?”

In nearly all cases, I strongly recommend taking the first “no” someone gives you. But people often try to be polite here, or might even feel slightly disheartened by the conversation having shifted, so this is one of the few exceptions. If they decline to go back to their topic, I will always ask if they’re sure one time. If they are sure they don’t want to go back, just pick up where you left off.

I’ve wasted a lot of energy trying to “fix” or undo the thing I did wrong. The reality is that you can’t, and that’s okay. Mistakes happen, that’s just part of being human. We all know this, and people are usually very gracious once you acknowledge it.

This goes for anything, now that I think of it. Not just this section.

Early Conversation and Small Talk

I'm convinced that the main reason people hate small talk is that they just don't understand it.

And that's fair. Because even though I've dedicated a huge amount of time and energy to understanding communication, it took me a while to wrap my head around why small talk even exists. It always just felt like a pointless, boring ritual that we couldn't help but put ourselves through.

Why small talk exists

But there is a purpose to small talk. Because even though you can *ultimately* talk about anything, it's hard to *start* there.

Imagine a total stranger walks up to you and launches straight into a story about one of their hobbies. No introduction, no finding out what you're interested in, no finding out what you already know about the topic first, straight to the deeper conversation. This *might* be neat if you happen to share that interest, but it would most likely be fairly jarring. Off-putting, even.

Even if you happen to get lucky and care about whatever they've chosen to talk about, you still haven't had a chance to adjust to the fact that you're now speaking to another person. So you now need to acclimate to the fact that you're having a

conversation, the newness of the stranger in front of you, *and* somehow try to stay engaged in what they're saying.

By starting a conversation with relatively safe, easy topics, you and the person you're speaking to have a chance to both:

- build familiarity and comfort with a new person, and
- establish a topic of mutual interest to start the conversation.

This sets you up for great conversations a lot more consistently than trying to skip it.

That said…most people are pretty bad at this. And if you don't know how to quickly find that topic of mutual interest, you're going to be stuck in a lot of boring conversations that never seem to go anywhere.

So let's fix that.

Don't get too cute

People often try to fix the boring small talk problem by coming up with "better" opening questions.

I've been told this works for some people, but it hasn't for me. At least not as a substitution for the more standard topics.

At this point, I'm certain I've heard every non-standard conversation starter people have thought of. I've also wasted an incredible amount of time trying to come up with something better

than the “boring” basics. But in this case, there’s a very good reason the norm has become the norm. The standard small talk topics and questions are so common because they are both low-risk and have a lot of potential for a good conversation.

This is why the question, “what do you like to do?” is so common. You’re never going to be upset that someone asked about your interests, so it would be hard to think of a lower risk question. And what could you possibly want to talk about more than the things you enjoy doing?

And every time I’ve seen a non-standard conversation starter “work” for someone, the conversation has inevitably come back to the basics. They’re just not something you can ignore.

So if these questions are inherently good, why do they fail to create good conversations so often?

Why conversations fail

The number one reason conversations fail to get past small talk is that people just don’t say enough.

And I empathize, it’s embarrassing to realize you’ve been talking for too long, and especially that you’re boring people. But most people overcorrect. They’re so afraid of oversharing that they’ll go out of their way to speak as little as possible. Or maybe they really are just trying to be polite and focus on the other

person. Either way, the result is the same: the conversation goes nowhere.

Because, yeah, oversharing can be annoying. But it's not exactly enjoyable to try to have a conversation with someone who barely speaks. If you strip away anything "extra," all that's left is boring questions and predictable answers. How are you supposed to be engaged in that conversation? How is anyone else?

Subcommunication of undersharing

Giving the minimum possible answer is not just narratively boring, it makes the person you're talking to feel like you don't want them to be there.

One of the ways we read another person's interest in a conversation - and by extension in us - is by the effort they put into it. So when someone gives the minimum possible answer, they signal that they're not willing to put any effort into the conversation, and are therefore disinterested.

I know this seems minor, but think back to when you've asked someone how they're doing. I'll bet you felt a real difference between them responding with, "good, you?" versus something like, "I'm feeling good, how are you?" There isn't even any additional information in the second response, but them

putting in that tiny bit of additional effort makes you feel like they want to be there.

The two sentence rule

Okay, so you're convinced you need to say more than the minimum. But oversharing still absolutely exists, so how much should you say? My personal rule is to try to speak in about 2 sentences at a time.

This goes for both answering questions and asking them. Share relevant details (feelings, experiences, values) in your answers, talk about your hobbies and work in terms of the 4 C's, and ask questions that guide others to speak in the same terms.

Author's note

I'm going to level with you here: I wanted to flesh this section out more before releasing version 1, but it's been a grueling process and I'm ready for a break.

I'll write more on it in future versions, and have more sections to come. However, this is still a complete answer - even if it's not a thorough one.

I'm only comfortable releasing the guide in this state because it is, in a way, complete: Everything I do in every conversation I have is built on the fundamentals in this guide thus far.

But I do intend it to be a living document. I have plans for sections like body language and starting conversations, and you will have access to every version as it comes out.

So while I'll certainly have more to say, it's time to get this information into the hands of people who need it.

And on that note, **thank you**.

I've lost count of how many hours have gone into this first releasable version, and I cannot imagine a better way to have spent that time.

Now it's time for me to skate.

Or sleep, we'll see.